

See also: Magna Carta 66–71 ■ The trial of Charles I 96–97 ■ The US Constitution and Bill of Rights 110–117 ■ The Universal Declaration of Human Rights 222–229

In an **absolute monarchy**, the king or queen has **complete control of the nation**.

In a **constitutional monarchy**, the **power of the king or queen is limited** by and shared with an elected parliament.

The **Bill of Rights** effectively took England from an absolute monarchy to a **constitutional monarchy**.

who was already married to James's daughter, Mary. They asked him to come to England to defend the faith.

When William of Orange landed in England in November 1688 and began marching his army toward London, support for King James fell away. James soon realized that his position was untenable and within a month fled to France. He had, in effect, abdicated his throne and handed it to William and Mary in a bloodless revolution—known as the Glorious Revolution.

Parliament convened in January 1689 and offered the crown jointly to William and Mary. The new monarchs signed a Declaration of Rights in Parliament, which was formally passed as the Bill of Rights.

The Bill of Rights

By ensuring the power of an elected Parliament under a constitutional monarchy, the Bill of Rights protected the freedoms of English citizens. It condemned James's misdeeds; ordered that sessions of Parliament be held frequently; required Parliament's consent for a monarch to rule, raise taxes, or suspend laws; guaranteed freedom of speech in parliamentary debates; and barred Catholics from the throne. It also banned the raising of an army in peacetime without the consent of Parliament.

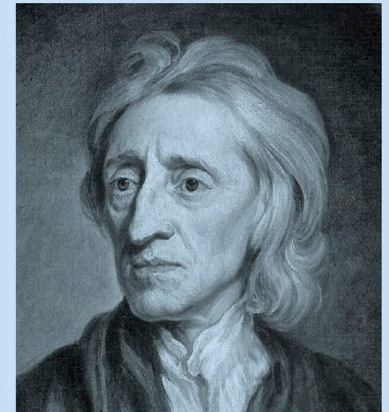
Together with the 1701 Act of Settlement, the Bill of Rights gave Parliament absolute sovereignty over all and any other government institutions and over succession to the throne, separating Parliament's powers from those of the Crown. In so doing, the Bill paved the way for the constitutional monarchy and parliamentary democracy that Britain has today. ■

Natural rights

The politicians who drafted the Bill of Rights were greatly influenced by the embryonic Enlightenment movement, most notably by English philosopher and scholar John Locke (1632–1704), and by the concept of natural rights.

Since ancient times, thinkers such as the Greek philosopher Aristotle had advocated that natural law, a universal code of behavior and rights, could not be denied by any legal system. Locke took up the baton. He believed in natural rights: that all men are naturally free and equal and have a right to life, liberty, and property.

Locke rejected the idea of the divine right of kings and absolute monarchy. He argued that a parliament should hold a central role in governing a country as part of a social contract with its people. This implied that, if the people believed that a government failed to represent their interests adequately, it should be replaced—an idea that would soon support revolution.



John Locke inspired thinkers in Europe's Enlightenment and the Founding Fathers who drafted the US Declaration of Independence.

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For redress of all grievances,
and for the amending,
strengthening, and
preserving of the laws,
Parliaments ought to be
held frequently.
**The English Bill
of Rights**